🔷 Identifying Pain Points

Week 1 • Day 4 • Customer-Centric Foundations

Technical Product Manager Academy

🎯 Day 4 Objectives

- Extract pain points from observed behavior, not just stated complaints
- Use **5 Whys** to reach root-cause pain
- Group raw pains into themes via **affinity mapping**
- Score pains on **Severity × Frequency × Addressability**
- Distinguish *pains we must fix* from *pains we must live with*

🕑 Today's Shape

Clock	Block	Outcome
09:00 – 09:15	Opening	Persona pains → pain-point candidates
09:15 – 10:30	Block 1 + Activity 1	Extraction from evidence
10:45 – 12:00	Block 2 + Activity 2	5 Whys + affinity mapping
13:00 – 14:15	Block 3 + Activity 3	Severity × Frequency × Addressability
14:30 – 16:00	Block 4 + Activity 4 + Readouts	Prioritization + must-live-with

Block 1 — Extraction

Where real pain hides

🔍 Where Pains Actually Live

Source	What you see	Reliability
Support tickets	Failures serious enough to complain about	High for severity, low for frequency
Interviews	Stated frustrations, with emotion	Medium; confirmation bias risk
Observation / ride-alongs	Workarounds, sighs, side-channels (paper, shared spreadsheets)	Highest for real pain
Analytics drop-offs	Where users quit a flow	High for "what," silent on "why"
Sales/loss reviews	Why deals didn't close	Medium; filtered through sales narrative

The best pain points are the ones customers *don't complain about anymore* — because they built a workaround.

🔷 A Pain Is a Verb

❌ Too vague

- "Bad UX"
- "Inefficient workflow"
- "Training problems"
- "Integration issues"

✅ Actionable

- "Dispatchers retype parts from paper tickets nightly"
- "Mid-day re-routes require calling 3–4 techs individually"
- "New dispatchers bounce from training after screen 5"
- "Truck inventory is off by end-of-week; no one notices until payroll"

👥 Activity 1 — Extract From the Packet

Triads • 45 minutes

Your triad receives the FieldPulse **Pain Extraction Packet** — 8 support tickets, 2 ride-along note pages, 4 interview excerpts, 1 analytics screenshot.

- Extract at least 15 candidate pains
- Each pain must be a verb + circumstance + consequence
- Tag source (ticket #, interview initials, observation) for every entry

⏱️ 10 min read · 25 min extract · 10 min review for verb/vagueness

Block 2 — Root Cause & Themes

5 Whys + affinity mapping

🔄 The 5 Whys, Used Well

Take a pain. Ask "Why does that happen?" Take the answer, ask "Why?" again. Five levels deep (usually fewer) you hit a root cause that is either **systemic** or **out of scope**.

```
L1: Dispatchers close books 45 min after shift end.
Why? They reconcile paper tickets from the day.
L2: They reconcile paper tickets.
Why? Techs submit paper (not mobile) tickets.
L3: Techs submit paper.
Why? The mobile app is slow on 3G in the field.
L4: Mobile app is slow on 3G.
Why? Ticket submission downloads all open jobs first.
L5: (Root cause — addressable) — Ticket submission is not
designed for intermittent connectivity.
```

📌 Affinity Mapping in 3 Moves

1. **Silent sort:** Each triad member places every pain on the wall (or whiteboard tool). No talking.
2. **Cluster:** Group related pains. Name each cluster with a *verb phrase*, not a category.
3. **Promote:** For each cluster, choose 1–2 pains that best represent the whole.

> **Silence matters:** The silent-sort step prevents the loudest voice from anchoring the map. Protect it.

👥 Activity 2 — Dig, Sort, Promote

Triads • 50 minutes

Using your Activity 1 pain list:

- Pick 3 pains that feel "surface-level" — run 5 Whys on each
- Do the silent sort on the full list
- End with 5–8 named clusters, each with 1–2 promoted representative pains

⏱️ 20 min 5 Whys · 20 min silent sort · 10 min cluster + promote

Block 3 — Severity × Frequency × Addressability

How to say no to real pain

📈 The Three Axes

Axis	Question	Scale
Severity	How bad is it when it happens?	Low (annoyance) → Medium (workaround) → High (blocked)
Frequency	How often does it happen?	Low (monthly+) → Medium (weekly) → High (daily)
Addressability	Can *we* fix it?	Low (org/regulatory) → Medium (partial) → High (fully within product)

Addressability is the axis PMs forget. High severity + high frequency + low addressability = we must communicate, not engineer.

🎯 Visualizing the Triangle

Plot each promoted pain in a 3×3 matrix (Severity down × Frequency across), then color-code by addressability.

Sev ↓ / Freq →
Low
High
High
Monitor
Must fix
Low
Accept
Automate / polish

Addressability colors: green = we can amber = partial red = out of scope

A red "Must fix" cell is a **communication problem**, not a product problem. Those need stakeholder framing, not JIRA tickets.

👥 Activity 3 — Score Your Map

Triads • 45 minutes

Place each promoted pain on the 3×3 matrix. Use evidence tiers from Day 1 when judging severity and frequency — don't guess.

- For every **red "Must fix"** pain, draft 2 sentences: "Why we cannot solve this" + "What we will do instead"
- Identify one pain where AI-augmented analysis could raise addressability (e.g., summarizing inbound to reduce support burden)

⏱️ 20 min place · 15 min addressability notes · 10 min AI-leverage

Block 4 — What We Take Forward

Top 3 pains → Friday's problem statement

🏆 Selecting the Top 3

Each triad picks the **three pains** that will drive Friday's problem statement. The selection must defend:

1. Why these three over the others? (Matrix position + evidence)
2. Are they *independent*, or aspects of the same root cause?
3. What's the single "if we solved this, everything else is easier" pain?

> **Tip:** A great top-3 is often rank-ordered such that #1 unblocks or reduces #2 and #3. If your three feel unrelated, look again for the shared root.

👥 Activity 4 — Cross-Triad Challenge

Paired triads • 60 minutes • Readouts

Each triad presents Top 3 + matrix to another triad. Partners must:

- Nominate the **weakest** of the three (not based on feel — based on the evidence tag)
- Propose one pain they *didn't* select that might be stronger, with reasoning
- Ask one "so what if we're wrong?" question per pain

After critique: 15 minutes to revise. Each triad readouts its final Top 3 in under 60 seconds.

⏱️ 20 min per direction · 15 min revise · 10 min readouts

🎉 Day 4 Wrap

What we built

- A scored pain-point matrix per triad
- A Top 3 pain set, rank-ordered and defended
- Language for "pains we must live with"

What opens tomorrow

- **Data-driven problem framing** — turning Top 3 into a problem statement an engineer can scope
- Friday afternoon: integrated Week 1 readouts

Bring to Day 5: Your Top 3 pain sheet with evidence tiers + the one pain you dropped that you're still wrestling with.

💬 Questions & Reflection

Which pain will you re-interview next week?